

king—the most skilful physiognomists, we say, would never have been able to fathom the depths of that abyss of mildness. It was with the eyes of the king as with the immense depths of the azure heavens, or with those more terrific, and almost as sublime, which the Mediterranean reveals under the keels of its ships in a clear summer day, a gigantic mirror in which heaven delights to reflect sometimes its stars, sometimes its storms.

The king was short of stature—he was scarcely five feet two inches: but his youth made up for this defect, set off likewise by great nobleness in all his movements, and by considerable address in all bodily exercises.

Certes, he was already quite a king, and it was a great thing to be a king in that period of traditional devotedness and respect; but as, up to that time, he had been but seldom and always poorly shown to the people, as they to whom he was shown saw him by the side of his mother, a tall woman, and *monsieur le cardinal*, a man of commanding presence, many found him so little of a king as to say,—

‘Why, the king is not so tall as *monsieur le cardinal*!’

Whatever may be thought of these physical observations, which were principally made in the capital, the young king was welcomed as a god by the inhabitants of Blois, and almost like a king by his uncle and aunt, *Monsieur* and *Madame*, the inhabitants of the castle.

It must, however, be allowed, that when he saw, in the hall of reception, chairs of equal height for himself, his mother, the cardinal, and his uncle and aunt, a disposition artfully concealed by the semi-circular form of the assembly, *Louis XIV* became red with anger, and looked around him to ascertain by the countenances of those that were present, if this humiliation had been prepared for him. But as he saw nothing upon the impassible visage of the cardinal, nothing on that of his mother, nothing on those of the assembly, he resigned himself, and sat down, taking care to be seated before anybody else.

The gentlemen and ladies were presented to their majesties and *monsieur le cardinal*.

The king remarked that his mother and he scarcely knew the names of any of the persons who were presented to them; whilst the cardinal, on the contrary, never failed, with an admirable memory and presence of mind, to talk to every one about his estates, his ancestors, or his children, some of whom he named, which enchanted those worthy country gentlemen, and confirmed them in

the idea that he alone is truly king who knows his subjects, from the same reason that the sun has no rival, because the sun alone warms and lightens.

The study of the young king, which had begun a long time before, without anybody suspecting it, was continued then, and he looked around him attentively to endeavour to make out something in the physiognomies which had at first appeared the most insignificant and trivial.

A collation was served. The king, without daring to call upon the hospitality of his uncle, had waited for it impatiently. This time, therefore, he had all the honours due, if not to his rank, at least to his appetite.

As to the cardinal, he contented himself with touching with his withered lips a bouillon, served in a golden cup. The all-powerful minister, who had taken her regency from the queen, and his royalty from the king, had not been able to take a good stomach from nature.

Anne of Austria, already suffering from the cancer which six or eight years after caused her death, ate very little more than the cardinal.

For *Monsieur*, already puffed up with the great event which had taken place in his provincial life, he ate nothing whatever.

Madame alone, like a true Lorrainer, kept pace with his majesty; so that *Louis XIV*, who, without this partner, might have eaten nearly alone, was at first much pleased with his aunt, and afterwards with *M. de Saint-Rémy*, her *mâtre d’hôtel*, who had really distinguished himself.

The collation over, at a sign of approbation from *M. de Mazarin*, the king arose, and, at the invitation of his aunt, walked about among the ranks of the assembly.

The ladies then observed—there are certain things for which women are as good observers at Blois as at Paris—the ladies then observed that *Louis XIV* had a prompt and bold look, which premised a distinguished appreciator of beauty. The men, on their part, observed that the prince was proud and haughty, that he loved to look down those who fixed their eyes upon him too long or too earnestly, which gave presage of a master.

Louis XIV had accomplished about a third of his review when his ears were struck with a word which his eminence pronounced whilst conversing with *Monsieur*.

This word was the name of a woman.

Scarcely had Louis XIV heard this word than he heard, or rather listening to nothing else; and neglecting the arc of the circle which awaited his visit, his object seemed to be to come as quickly as possible to the extremity of the curve.

Monsieur, like a good courtier, was inquiring of monsieur le cardinal after the health of his nieces; he regretted, he said, not having the pleasure of receiving them at the same time with their uncle; they must certainly have grown in stature, beauty and grace, as they had promised to do the last time Monsieur had seen them.

What had first struck the king was a certain constraint in the voices of the two interlocutors. The voice of Monsieur was calm and natural when he spoke thus; while that of M. de Mazarin jumped by a note and a half to reply above the diapason of his usual voice. It might have been said that he wished that voice to strike, at the end of the salon, any ear that was too distant.

‘Monseigneur,’ replied he, ‘Mesdemoiselles de Mazarin have still to finish their education: they have duties to fulfil, and a position to make. An abode in a young and brilliant court would dissipate them a little.’

Louis, at this last sentence, smiled sadly. The court was young, it was true, but the avarice of the cardinal had taken good care that it should not be brilliant.

‘You have nevertheless no intention,’ replied Monsieur, ‘to cloister them or make them *bourgeoises*?’

‘Not at all,’ replied the cardinal, forcing his Italian pronunciation in such a manner that, from soft and velvety as it was, it became sharp and vibrating; ‘not at all: I have a full and fixed intention to marry them, and that as well as I shall be able.’

‘Parties will not be wanting, monsieur le cardinal,’ replied Monsieur, with a bonhomie worthy of one tradesman congratulating another.

‘I hope not, monseigneur, and with reason, as God has been pleased to give them grace, intelligence, and beauty.’

During this conversation, Louis XIV, conducted by Madame, accomplished, as we have described, the circle of presentations.

‘Mademoiselle Auricule,’ said the princess, presenting to his majesty a fat, fair girl of two-and-twenty, who at a village fête might have been taken for a peasant in Sunday finery,—‘the daughter of my music-mistress.’

Chapter VIII

What His Majesty King Louis XIV Was at the Age of Twenty-Two



It has been seen, by the account we have endeavoured to give of it, that the entrée of King Louis XIV into the city of Blois had been noisy and brilliant; his young majesty had therefore appeared perfectly satisfied with it.

On arriving beneath the porch of the Castle of the States, the king met, surrounded by his guards and gentlemen, with S. A. R. the duke, Gaston of Orléans, whose physiognomy, naturally rather majestic, had borrowed on this solemn occasion a fresh lustre and a fresh dignity. On her part, Madame, dressed in her robes of ceremony, awaited, in the interior balcony, the entrance of her nephew. All the windows of the old castle, so deserted and dismal on ordinary days, were resplendent with ladies and lights.

It was then to the sound of drums, trumpets, and vivats, that the young king crossed the threshold of that castle in which, seventy-two years before, Henry III had called in the aid of assassination and treachery to keep upon his head and in his house a crown which was already slipping from his brow, to fall into another family.

All eyes, after having admired the young king, so handsome and so agreeable, sought for that other king of France, much otherwise king than the former, and so old, so pale, so bent, that people called the Cardinal Mazarin.

Louis was at this time endowed with all the natural gifts which make the perfect gentleman; his eye was brilliant, mild, and of a clear azure blue. But the most skilful physiognomists, those divers into the soul, on fixing their looks upon it, if it had been possible for a subject to sustain the glance of the

when all Europe will become acquainted with what you have told me. Parry, are there not examples in which a man of my condition should himself—'

'My lord, in the name of Heaven—'

'You are right, Parry; I am a coward, and if I do nothing for myself, what will God do? No, no; I have two arms, Parry, and I have a sword.' And he struck his arm violently with his hand, and took down his sword, which hung against the wall.

'What are you going to do, my lord?'

'What am I going to do, Parry? What every one in my family does. My mother lives on public charity, my sister begs for my mother; I have, somewhere or other, brothers who equally beg for themselves; and I, the eldest, will go and do as all the rest do—I will go and ask charity!'

And with these words, which he finished sharply with a nervous and terrible laugh, the young man girded on his sword, took his hat from the trunk, fastened to his shoulder a black cloak, which he had worn all during his journey, and pressing the two hands of the old man, who watched his proceedings with a look of anxiety,—

'My good Parry,' said he, 'order a fire, drink, eat, sleep, and be happy; let us both be happy, my faithful friend, my only friend. We are rich, as rich as kings!'

He struck the bag of pistols with his clenched hand as he spoke, and it fell heavily to the ground. He resumed that dismal laugh that had so alarmed Parry; and whilst the whole household was screaming, singing, and preparing to install the travellers who had been preceded by their lackeys, he glided out by the principal entrance into the street, where the old man, who had gone to the window, lost sight of him in a moment.

The king smiled. Madame had never been able to extract four correct notes from either viol or hapsichord.

'Mademoiselle Aure de Montalais,' continued Madame; 'a young lady of rank, and my good attendant.'

This time it was not the king that smiled; it was the young lady presented, because, for the first time in her life, she heard, given to her by Madame, who generally showed no tendency to spoil her, such an honourable qualification.

Our old acquaintance Montalais, therefore, made his majesty a profound courtesy, the more respectful from the necessity she was under of concealing certain contractions of her laughing lips, which the king might not have attributed to their real cause.

It was just at this moment that the king caught the word which startled him.

'And the name of the third?' asked Monsieur.

'Mary, monseigneur,' replied the cardinal.

There was doubtless some magical influence in that word, for, as we have said, the king started in hearing it, and drew Madame towards the middle of the circle, as if he wished to put some confidential question to her, but, in reality, for the sake of getting nearer to the cardinal.

'Madame, my aunt,' said he, laughing, and in a suppressed voice, 'my geography-master did not teach me that Blois was at such an immense distance from Paris.'

'What do you mean, nephew?' asked Madame.

'Why, because it would appear that it requires several years, as regards fashion, to travel the distance!—Look at those young ladies!'

'Well; I know them all.'

'Some of them are pretty.'

'Don't say that too loud, monsieur my nephew; you will drive them wild.'

'Stop a bit, stop a bit, dear aunt!' said the king, smiling; 'for the second part of my sentence will serve as a corrective to the first. Well, my dear aunt, some of them appear old and others ugly, thanks to their ten-year-old fashions.'

'But, sire, Blois is only five days' journey from Paris.'

'Yes, that is it,' said the king; 'two years behind for each day.'

'Indeed! do you really think so? Well, that is strange! It never struck me.'

'Now, look, aunt,' said Louis XIV, drawing still nearer to Mazarin, under the pretext of gaining a better point of view, 'look at that simple white dress by the side of those antiquated specimens of finery, and those pretentious coiffures. She is probably one of my mother's maids of honour, though I don't know her.'

'Ah! ah! my dear nephew?' replied Madame, laughing; 'permit me to tell you that your divinatory science is at fault for once. The young lady you honour with your praise is not a Parisian, but a Blaisoise.'

'Oh, aunt!' replied the king with a look of doubt.

'Come here, Louise,' said Madame.

And the fair girl, already known to you under that name, approached them, timid, blushing, and almost bent beneath the royal glance.

'Mademoiselle Louise Françoise de la Beaume le Blanc, the daughter of the Marquise de La Vallière,' said Madame, ceremoniously.

The young girl bowed with so much grace, mingled with the profound timidity inspired by the presence of the king, that the latter lost, while looking at her, a few words of the conversation of Monsieur and the cardinal.

'Daughter-in-law,' continued Madame, 'of M. de Saint-Rémy, my maître d'hôtel, who presided over the confection of that excellent daube truffée which your majesty seemed so much to appreciate.'

No grace, no youth, no beauty, could stand out against such a presentation. The king smiled. Whether the words of Madame were a pleasantry, or uttered in all innocence, they proved the pitiless immolation of everything that Louis had found charming or poetic in the young girl. Mademoiselle de La Vallière, for Madame and, by rebound, for the king, was, for a moment, no more than the daughter of a man of a superior talent over dindes truffées.

But princes are thus constituted. The gods, too, were just like this in Olympus. Diana and Venus, no doubt, abused the beautiful Alcmena and poor Io, when they condescended for distraction's sake, to speak, amidst nectar and ambrosia, of mortal beauties, at the table of Jupiter.

Fortunately, Louise was so bent in her reverential salure, that she did not catch either Madame's words or the king's smile. In fact, if the poor child, who had so much good taste as alone to have chosen to dress herself in white amidst all her companions—if that dove's heart, so easily accessible to painful

'Yes, my lord.'

'And notwithstanding you had signed the name Parry?'

'To all my letters, my lord; and the aide-de-camp had known me at St James's and at Whitehall, too,' added the old man with a sigh.

The young man leaned forward, thoughtful and sad.

'Ay, that's what he did before his people,' said he, endeavouring to cheat himself with hopes. 'But, privately—between you and him—what did he do? Answer!'

'Alas! my lord, he sent to me four cavaliers, who gave me the horse with which you just now saw me come back. These cavaliers conducted me, in great haste, to the little port of Tenby, threw me, rather than embarked me, into a little fishing-boat, about to sail for Brittany, and here I am.'

'Oh!' sighed the young man, clasping his neck convulsively with his hand, and with a sob. 'Parry, is that all?—is that all?'

'Yes, my lord; that is all.'

After this brief reply ensued a long interval of silence, broken only by the convulsive beating of the heel of the young man on the floor.

The old man endeavoured to change the conversation; it was leading to thoughts much too sinister.

'My lord,' said he, 'what is the meaning of all the noise which preceded me? What are these people crying "Vive le Roi!" for? What king do they mean? and what are all these lights for?'

'Ah! Parry,' replied the young man ironically, 'don't you know that this is the King of France visiting his good city of Blois? All these trumpets are his, all those gilded housings are his, all those gentlemen wear swords that are his. His mother precedes him in a carriage magnificently encrusted with silver and gold. Happy mother! His minister heaps up millions, and conducts him to a rich bride. Then all these people rejoice; they love their king, they hail him with their acclamations, and they cry, "Vive le Roi! Vive le Roi!"'

'Well, well, my lord,' said Parry, more uneasy at the turn the conversation had taken than at the other.

'You know,' resumed the unknown, 'that my mother and my sister, whilst all this is going on in honour of the King of France, have neither money nor bread; you know that I myself shall be poor and degraded within a fortnight,

'Parry, I conjure you to tell me nothing; for if your news had been good, you would not have begun in such a manner; you go about, which proves that the news is bad.'

'My lord,' said the old man, 'do not hasten to alarm yourself; all is not lost, I hope. You must employ energy, but more particularly resignation.'

'Parry,' said the young man, 'I have reached this place through a thousand snares and after a thousand difficulties; can you doubt my energy? I have meditated this journey ten years, in spite of all counsels and all obstacles—have you faith in my perseverance? I have this evening sold the last of my father's diamonds; for I had nothing wherewith to pay for my lodgings and my host was about to turn me out.'

Parry made a gesture of indignation, to which the young man replied by a pressure of the hand and a smile.

'I have still two hundred and seventy-four pistols left and I feel myself rich. I do not despair, Parry; have you faith in my resignation?'

The old man raised his trembling hands towards heaven.

'Let me know,' said the stranger,—'disguise nothing from me—what has happened?'

'My recital will be short, my lord; but in the name of Heaven do not tremble so.'

'It is impatience, Parry. Come, what did the general say to you?'

'At first the general would not receive me.'

'He took you for a spy?'

'Yes, my lord; but I wrote him a letter.'

'Well?'

'He read it, and received me, my lord.'

'Did that letter thoroughly explain my position and my views?'

'Oh, yes!' said Parry, with a sad smile; 'it painted your very thoughts faithfully.'

'Well—then, Parry.'

'Then the general sent me back the letter by an aide-de-camp, informing me that if I were found the next day within the circumference of his command, he would have me arrested.'

'Arrested!' murmured the young man. 'What! arrest you, my most faithful servant?'

emotions, had been touched by the cruel words of Madame, or the egotistical cold smile of the king, it would have annihilated her.

And Montalais herself, the girl of ingenious ideas, would not have attempted to recall her to life; for ridicule kills beauty even.

But fortunately, as we have said, Louise, whose ears were buzzing, and her eyes veiled by timidity,—Louise saw nothing and heard nothing; and the king, who had still his attention directed to the conversation of the cardinal and his uncle, hastened to return to them.

He came up just at the moment Mazarin terminated by saying: 'Mary, as well as her sisters, has just set off for Brouage. I make them follow the opposite bank of the Loire to that along which we have travelled; and if I calculate their progress correctly, according to the orders I have given, they will to-morrow be opposite Blois.'

These words were pronounced with that tact—that measure, that distinctness of tone, of intention, and reach—which made del Signor Giulio Mazarini the first comedian in the world.

It resulted that they went straight to the heart of Louis XIV, and the cardinal, on turning round at the simple noise of the approaching footsteps of his majesty, saw the immediate effect of them upon the countenance of his pupil, an effect betrayed to the keen eyes of his eminence by a slight increase of colour. But what was the ventilation of such a secret to him whose craft had for twenty years deceived all the diplomatists of Europe?

From the moment the young king heard these last words, he appeared as if he had received a poisoned arrow in his heart. He could not remain quiet in a place, but cast around an uncertain, dead, and aimless look over the assembly. He with his eyes interrogated his mother more than twenty times: but she, given up to the pleasure of conversing with her sister-in-law, and likewise constrained by the glance of Mazarin, did not appear to comprehend any of the supplications conveyed by the looks of her son.

From this moment, music, lights, flowers, beauties, all became odious and insipid to Louis XIV. After he had a hundred times bitten his lips, stretched his legs and his arms like a well-brought-up child, who, without daring to gape, exhausts all the modes of evincing his weariness—after having uselessly again implored his mother and the minister, he turned a despairing look towards the door, that is to say, towards liberty.

At this door, in the embrasure of which he was leaning, he saw, standing out strongly, a figure with a brown and lofty countenance, an aquiline nose, a stern but brilliant eye, gray and long hair, a black moustache, the true type of military beauty, whose gorget, more sparkling than a mirror, broke all the reflected lights which concentrated upon it, and sent them back as lightning. This officer wore his gray hat with its long red plumes upon his head, a proof that he was called there by his duty, and not by his pleasure. If he had been brought thither by his pleasure—if he had been a courtier instead of a soldier, as pleasure must always be paid for at the same price—he would have held his hat in his hand.

That which proved still better that this officer was upon duty, and was accomplishing a task to which he was accustomed, was, that he watched, with folded arms, remarkable indifference, and supreme apathy, the joys and ennuis of this fête. Above all, he appeared, like a philosopher, and all old soldiers are philosophers,—he appeared above all to comprehend the ennuis infinitely better than the joys; but in the one he took his part, knowing very well how to do without the other.

Now, he was leaning, as we have said, against the carved door-frame when the melancholy, weary eyes of the king, by chance, met his.

It was not the first time, as it appeared, that the eyes of the officer had met those eyes, and he was perfectly acquainted with the expression of them; for, as soon as he had cast his own look upon the countenance of Louis XIV, and had read by it what was passing in his heart—that is to say, all the ennui that oppressed him—all the timid desire to go out which agitated him,—he perceived he must render the king a service without his commanding it,—almost in spite of himself. Boldly, therefore, as if he had given the word of command to cavalry in battle, ‘On the king’s service!’ cried he, in a clear, sonorous voice.

At these words, which produced the effect of a peal of thunder, prevailing over the orchestra, the singing and the buzz of the promenaders, the cardinal and the queen-mother looked at each other with surprise.

Louis XIV, pale, but resolved, supported as he was by that intuition of his own thought which he had found in the mind of the officer of musketeers, and which he had just manifested by the order given, arose from his chair, and took a step towards the door.

The noise of the trumpets excited him—the popular acclamations deafened him: for a moment he allowed his reason to be absorbed in this flood of lights, tumult, and brilliant images.

‘He is a king!’ murmured he, in an accent of despair.

Then, before he had recovered from his sombre reverie, all the noise, all the splendour, had passed away. At the angle of the street there remained nothing beneath the stranger but a few hoarse, discordant voices, shouting at intervals ‘Vive le Roi!’

There remained likewise the six candles held by the inhabitants of the hostelry des Medici; that is to say, two for Cropole, two for Pittirino, and one for each scullion. Cropole never ceased repeating, ‘How good-looking the king is! How strongly he resembles his illustrious father!’

‘A handsome likeness!’ said Pittirino.

‘And what a lofty carriage he has!’ added Madame Cropole, already in promiscuous commentary with her neighbours of both sexes.

Cropole was feeding their gossip with his own personal remarks, without observing that an old man on foot, but leading a small Irish horse by the bridle, was endeavouring to penetrate the crowd of men and women which blocked up the entrance to the Medici. But at that moment the voice of the stranger was heard from the window.

‘Make way, monsieur l’hôtelier, to the entrance of your house!’

Cropole turned around, and, on seeing the old man, cleared a passage for him.

The window was instantly closed.

Pittirino pointed out the way to the newly-arrived guest, who entered without uttering a word.

The stranger waited for him on the landing; he opened his arms to the old man, and led him to a seat.

‘Oh, no, no, my lord!’ said he. ‘Sit down in your presence?—never!’

‘Parry,’ cried the gentleman, ‘I beg you will, you come from England—you come so far. Ah! it is not for your age to undergo the fatigues my service requires. Rest yourself.’

‘I have my reply to give your lordship, in the first place.’

'Now,' said he, 'I hope monsieur will not give me the pain of not taking any supper. Dinner has already been refused; this is affronting to the house of les Medici. Look, monsieur, the supper is on the table, and I venture to say that it is not a bad one.'

The unknown asked for a glass of wine, broke off a morsel of bread, and did not stir from the window whilst he ate and drank.

Shortly after was heard a loud flourish of trumpets; cries arose in the distance, a confused buzzing filled the lower part of the city, and the first distinct sound that struck the ears of the stranger was the tramp of advancing horses.

'The king! the king!' repeated a noisy and eager crowd.

'The king!' cried Cropole, abandoning his guest and his ideas of delicacy, to satisfy his curiosity.

With Cropole were mingled, and jostled, on the staircase, Madame Cropole, Pitrino, and the waiters and scullions.

The cortège advanced slowly, lighted by a thousand flambeaux, in the streets and from the windows.

After a company of musketeers, a closely ranked troop of gentlemen, came the litter of monsieur le cardinal, drawn like a carriage by four black horses. The pages and people of the cardinal marched behind.

Next came the carriage of the queen-mother, with her maids of honour at the doors, her gentlemen on horseback at both sides.

The king then appeared, mounted upon a splendid horse of Saxon breed, with a flowing mane. The young prince exhibited, when bowing to some windows from which issued the most animated acclamations, a noble and handsome countenance, illuminated by the flambeaux of his pages.

By the side of the king, though a little in the rear, the Prince de Condé, M. Dangeau, and twenty other courtiers, followed by their people and their baggage, closed this veritably triumphant march. The pomp was of a military character.

Some of the courtiers—the elder ones, for instance—wore travelling dresses; but all the rest were clothed in warlike panoply. Many wore the gorget and buff coat of the times of Henry IV and Louis XIII.

When the king passed before him, the unknown, who had leant forward over the balcony to obtain a better view, and who had concealed his face by leaning on his arm, felt his heart swell and overflow with a bitter jealousy.

'Are you going, my son?' said the queen, whilst Mazarin satisfied himself with interrogating by a look which might have appeared mild if it had not been so piercing.

'Yes, madame,' replied the king; 'I am fatigued, and, besides, wish to write this evening.'

A smile stole over the lips of the minister, who appeared, by a bend of the head, to give the king permission.

Monsieur and Madame hastened to give orders to the officers who presented themselves.

The king bowed, crossed the hall, and gained the door, where a hedge of twenty musketeers awaited him. At the extremity of this hedge stood the officer, impassible, with his drawn sword in his hand. The king passed, and all the crowd stood on tip-toe, to have one more look at him.

Ten musketeers, opening the crowd of the ante-chambers and the steps, made way for his majesty. The other ten surrounded the king and Monsieur, who had insisted upon accompanying his majesty. The domestics walked behind. This little cortège escorted the king to the chamber destined for him. The apartment was the same that had been occupied by Henry III during his sojourn in the States.

Monsieur had given his orders. The musketeers, led by their officer, took possession of the little passage by which one wing of the castle communicates with the other. This passage was commenced by a small square ante-chamber, dark even in the finest days. Monsieur stopped Louis XIV.

'You are passing now, sire,' said he, 'the very spot where the Duc de Guise received the first stab of the poniard.'

The king was ignorant of all historical matters; he had heard of the fact, but he knew nothing of the localities or the details.

'Ah!' said he with a shudder.

And he stopped. The rest, both behind and before him, stopped likewise. 'The duc, sire,' continued Gaston, 'was nearly where I stand: he was walking in the same direction as your majesty; M. de Loignac was exactly where your lieutenant of musketeers is; M. de Saint-Maline and his majesty's ordinaries were behind him and around him. It was here that he was struck.'

The king turned towards his officer, and saw something like a cloud pass over his martial and daring countenance.

'Yes, from behind!' murmured the lieutenant, with a gesture of supreme disdain. And he endeavoured to resume the march, as if ill at ease at being between walls formerly defiled by treachery.

But the king, who appeared to wish to be informed, was disposed to give another look at this dismal spot.

Gaston perceived his nephew's desire.

'Look, sire,' said he, taking a flambeau from the hands of M. de Saint-Rémy, 'this is where he fell. There was a bed there, the curtains of which he tore with catching at them.'

'Why does the floor seem hollowed out at this spot?' asked Louis.

'Because it was here the blood flowed,' replied Gaston; 'the blood penetrated deeply into the oak, and it was only by cutting it out that they succeeded in making it disappear. And even then,' added Gaston, pointing the flambeau to the spot, 'even then this red stain resisted all the attempts made to destroy it.'

Louis XIV raised his head. Perhaps he was thinking of that bloody trace that had once been shown him at the Louvre, and which, as a pendant to that of Blois, had been made there one day by the king his father with the blood of Concini.

'Let us go on,' said he.

The march was resumed promptly; for emotion, no doubt, had given to the voice of the young prince a tone of command which was not customary with him. When he arrived at the apartment destined for the king, which communicated not only with the little passage we have passed through, but further with the great staircase leading to the court,—

'Will your majesty,' said Gaston, 'condescend to occupy this apartment, all unworthy as it is to receive you?'

'Uncle,' replied the young king, 'I render you my thanks for your cordial hospitality.'

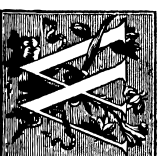
Gaston bowed to his nephew, embraced him, and then went out.

Of the twenty musketeers who had accompanied the king, ten reconducted Monsieur to the reception-rooms, which were not yet empty, notwithstanding the king had retired.

The ten others were posted by their officer, who himself explored, in five minutes, all the localities, with that cold and certain glance which not even habit gives unless that glance belongs to genius.

Chapter VII

Parry



HU!ST the unknown was viewing these lights with interest, and lending an ear to the various noises, Master Cropole entered his apartment, followed by two attendants, who laid the cloth for his meal.

The stranger did not pay them the least attention; but Cropole approaching him respectfully, whispered, 'Monsieur, the diamond has been valued.'

'Ah!' said the traveller. 'Well?'

'Well, monsieur, the jeweller of S. A. R. gives two hundred and eighty pistoles for it.'

'Have you them?'

'I thought it best to take them, monsieur; nevertheless, I made it a condition of the bargain, that if monsieur wished to keep his diamond, it should be held till monsieur was again in funds.'

'Oh, no, not at all: I told you to sell it.'

'Then I have obeyed, or nearly so, since, without having definitely sold it, I have touched the money.'

'Pay yourself,' added the unknown.

'I will do so, monsieur, since you so positively require it.'

A sad smile passed over the lips of the gentleman.

'Place the money on that trunk,' said he, turning round and pointing to the piece of furniture.

Cropole deposited a tolerably large bag as directed, after having taken from it the amount of his reckoning.